

CORE FORMULA

Context + optional invitation + easy exit + warm acceptance. -> A few of us are getting coffee after the session. You're welcome to join if you want — no problem either way. -> I'm collecting thoughts on the draft. If you have a quick reaction, I'd value it, but no need if your plate is full. -> If you want to say more about that, I'm interested. If not, we can leave it there. -> Integrity test: could they decline without losing warmth, status, access, or a future opportunity? If not, it isn't low-pressure.

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

You're welcome to join if you want — and no problem at all if not.

BEST FOR

- Social invitations where you want warmth without neediness
- Group discussions where a quieter person may want an entry point
- Professional collaboration where participation is genuinely optional
- Digital follow-ups where the other person may be busy
- Inviting disclosure, feedback, or help without forcing intimacy
- Re-opening a thread after silence, delay, or interruption

PHRASE BANK

Quick · Short openers

- "You're welcome to join if you want — no problem if not."
- "This is an open door, not an obligation."
- "You can pass on this one."
- "Join only if it suits you."
- "No rush to reply — I just wanted to leave the door open."
- "Genuinely optional, your call either way."
- "Only if it's useful to you."
- "No need to explain if it's a no."

Social invitations · Warmth without neediness

- "A few of us are grabbing lunch after this. You're welcome to come along if you feel like it — no pressure."
- "I'm walking that way too. Happy to walk together, or no worries if you'd rather have some quiet."
- "A few of us are heading over after this. You'd be very welcome, and it's completely fine if you'd rather a quiet night."
- "We're heading over at six. You're very very welcome if it sounds good, and no worries if you'd rather a quiet one."
- "If you want to join the conversation, there's room. If you'd rather just listen, that's fine too."
- "You'd be very welcome if it sounds good — and it's completely fine if tonight's a recovery night."
- "We'd love to have you, and it's no trouble at all if the timing's wrong."

Work and collaboration · Meetings, reviews, feedback

- "If you have a view, I'd be glad to hear it. Also fine to pass if this isn't your lane."
- "I can send you the draft for comment, but only if it's useful — no need to add another task to your week."
- "Would you like to be in on the next review, or would you rather I just send the summary?"
- "Optional: I can include you in the review. It's about a thirty-minute read, so please decline if your week is full."
- "I'm gathering quick reactions to the onboarding draft. One confusing bit would be useful — and if not, no problem."
- "If you have capacity, one quick reaction by tomorrow would help. If your week's full, no need — I can move with what I have."

- "We're testing the new format on Friday. Sit in if it's helpful, skip it if it's not."

Naming the option · Explicit opt-in / opt-out

- "You can answer now, later, or not at all."
- "We can go into it, or leave it at that — your call."
- "You can jump in if you want, and it's also fine to just listen."
- "Would you like in on this, or would you rather sit it out? Both are easy."
- "There's a full version and a lighter version — take whichever fits, or neither."
- "Say the word and I'll add you; say nothing and I'll take that as a no."

When the opt-out must be credible · Power gaps and guarded moments

- "I don't want to put you on the spot. You can answer now, later, or not at all."
- "Only if you're comfortable — what would be useful for me to know here?"
- "You can pass on this one, and it won't count against you."
- "I've got a bit more authority here, so I want to be clear: this is optional, and there's no downside to declining."
- "There's no expectation attached to this. A no is a completely fine answer."

Softening a loaded invite · Taking the pressure back out

- "I realise that may have sounded more loaded than I meant. It's genuinely optional."
- "Let me take the pressure out of that — only if it suits."
- "That came out pushier than I intended. No pressure at all."
- "I should have been clearer about what's involved. Feel free to pass."
- "Ignore the urgency in how I said that. There's no rush."

Disclosure and presence · Leaving room to open up

- "If you want to say more, I'm here. If you'd rather not, that's completely okay."
- "We can go into it or leave it there — whatever feels right."
- "No need to get into it now — the offer stands whenever."
- "I'm happy to listen if it helps, and just as happy to talk about something else."
- "You don't owe me the details. I just wanted you to know the door's open."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: You should come. Everyone will be there.

Better: We're going. You can come if you want.

Best: A few of us are going after the session. You're very welcome to join if you want — and no problem at all if you'd rather head off.

2. Weak: Can you give me feedback by tomorrow? No pressure.

Better: If you have time, could you send one quick reaction by tomorrow?

Best: If you have capacity, one quick reaction by tomorrow would help. If your week's full, no need — I can move with what I have.

3. Weak: Come on, tell me what actually happened.

Better: You can tell me what happened if you want.

Best: If you want to talk it through, I'm here — and it's completely fine to leave it for now.

DECISION TREE

If Is participation genuinely optional?

If no, don't use this move — make a clear request or state the requirement plainly instead.

"This part's actually required, so I'll be straight about it."

If Power gap, social risk, or chance of guilt?

If yes, make the exit ramp explicit and behaviourally credible; if no, a lighter line is enough.

"There's genuinely no downside to declining — I want to be clear about that."

If Can you accept a no without resentment or chasing?

If no, pause and release the pressure on yourself before you invite anyone.

"Whatever they choose is fine — I'll keep it to one ask."

If Inviting them to join something

Name the event, roughly how long it takes, and the option to skip.

"We're on at six for about an hour — very welcome if it suits, easy to skip if not."

If Inviting a view, a reply, or a disclosure

Invite the input and make passing, delaying, or going lighter equally acceptable.

"If you've a quick thought I'd value it; if not, leave it."

If They hesitate or push back

Reduce the scope and re-release the choice; if resistance holds, switch to Resistance-as-information (TC073).

"No need to decide now — the offer just stays open."

SCENARIOS

Social event invitation

Name the event and make both joining and not joining safe. — "We're heading over at six. You're very welcome if it sounds good, and no worries if you'd rather a quiet night."

A quiet person in a group

Offer an entry point without spotlighting them. — "Sam, if you have a view I'd like to hear it — and it's completely fine to pass."

Digital follow-up to someone busy

Make the invitation useful and genuinely optional. — "If you have one quick thought, I'd appreciate it. If not, no need to reply."

Someone hints at something personal

Leave the door open without pulling on it. — "If you want to say more, I'm here. If not, we can leave it there."

Including someone in optional work

Clarify the option, the cost, and that a no is fine. — "Optional: I can include you in the review. It's about a thirty-minute read, so please decline if your week is full."

After they decline

Accept it cleanly and keep the warmth intact. — "Of course. Thanks for letting me know — hope the rest of the week's lighter."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- The action is genuinely required and needs to be named as required
- There is a safety, legal, clinical, or compliance issue that needs direct language
- A power difference makes "no pressure" hard to believe
- You will resent, punish, repeatedly chase, or quietly shame a no
- The invitation hides cost, commitment, visibility, or obligation
- Physical safety or an immediate emergency takes priority

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Pressure scan

List three invitations you make often — one social, one work, one digital. For each, underline the hidden pressure: urgency, guilt, public exposure, obligation, hidden cost, or a demand to explain.

Day 2 — Four-part rewrite

Rewrite each one using the formula: context + optional invitation + easy exit + warm acceptance. Read them aloud; if any sounds needy or defensive, simplify it.

Day 3 — Write the refusal response

For each invitation, write how you'd reply if they decline. Each refusal response must be shorter than the invitation and must not ask them to justify the no.

Day 4 — Convert the pushy classics

Turn "You should come" into a low-pressure invitation, and "Can you review this?" into an optional contribution.

Day 5 — Disclosure and time-boxing

Turn "Tell me what happened" into a disclosure invitation, and "Join the call" into a time-bounded optional invite that

names how long it takes.

Day 6 — Public to private, and the open door

Take one invitation that would be awkward to decline in public and rewrite it as a private message. Then convert "Why didn't you reply?" into a clean open door.

Day 7 — Live use and the one-invitation rule

Use one low-pressure invitation in a real conversation. Say it once, don't re-sell it, and notice whether the person could decline without protecting your feelings.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Is the invitation genuinely optional?
- Have I named the actual activity, time, effort, or exposure?
- Can they decline without having to explain?
- Am I offering warmth without creating a debt?
- Will I stop after one invitation and accept their answer cleanly?
- Would I be comfortable if someone used this exact invitation on me?